



Germany and the Alpine States

LYING AT THE VERY HEART OF EUROPE, Germany is one of the world's wealthiest nations. It is also Europe's leading industrial power. To its south lie the Alpine states of Switzerland, Austria, Liechtenstein, and Slovenia. The region is famed for its beautiful Alpine scenery, mountains, and lakes. German is the main language in all but Slovenia. However, each of the five countries has its own distinct history, culture, and national identity. Indeed, since 1815, Switzerland has been recognized as a neutral nation, and has stayed out of all the wars that have affected Europe.

THE JOY OF UNIFICATION

After World War II, Germany was split, with a US-backed capitalist state in the west and a Russian-backed state in the east. Built in 1961, the Berlin Wall was 96 miles (155 km) long and was designed to stop East Germans from leaving for a better life in the West. The wall divided Berlin and separated families, friends, and a nation for 28 years. When Germany was unified (reunited) in 1990, the wall was officially demolished.



GERMAN INDUSTRY

With its coal and iron mines, the Ruhr Valley was once the powerhouse of the German economy. Today's industry ranges from engineering to high-tech goods. Quality assembly and design make Germany the fourth-largest car producer in the world.



FOOD AND DRINK

The annual Munich Oktoberfest is Germany's biggest beer festival. Entertainment includes parades and music.



Celebrations at the Brandenburg Gate marking the 10th anniversary of the fall of the Berlin Wall

GENEVA
Geneva lies on the shores of Lake Geneva, Europe's largest Alpine lake. This orderly city is a global center for banking and finance. It is also a base for many international organizations, such as the Red Cross.



The Swiss speak German, French, Italian, and Romansh.